



Major role: Manav Thakkar had a huge part to play in the Indian men's team's third straight bronze medal at the Asian Championships. *M. VEDHAN*

level and three men's team bronze medals from the Asian Championships in Doha (Qatar, 2021), Pyeongchang (South Korea, 2023), and Astana (Kazakhstan, 2024) have all contributed to India's newfound identity and respect among the world's best.

Though the domestic structure, comprising the National Championship, Inter-Institutional Championship, and five National Ranking tournaments, is considered adequate by those governing the sport, overseas participation has increased significantly due to individual initiatives.

The introduction of the Ultimate Table Tennis League has also played a key role in helping Indian players test their skills against some of the top 25 ranked players in both categories. Training as teammates with these higher-ranked overseas players for their respective franchises has enabled Indians to shed self-doubts in their preparations for international competitions.

At the 2024 Astana Championship,

where withdrawals and upsets in individual events raised several eyebrows, Japan won three gold, two silver, and three bronze medals to top the tally, ahead of China (two gold, two silver, and a bronze), DPR Korea (a gold, a silver, and a bronze), and South Korea (a gold and three bronzes).

India returned with three bronze medals, matching its previous best (bronze in the men's team and two in men's doubles in 2021) since 1972, when the competition was renamed. From 1952 to 1970, the continental championship was organised by the Table Tennis Federation of Asia before the Asian Table Tennis Union took over. India's first bronze came in the women's team event in the 1960 edition.

The format of the continental team championship places the top six teams from the previous edition in the Champions Division. These teams await two teams from the First Division League in the knockout phase, starting from the quarterfinals.

The Indian men's team, by virtue of finishing fifth in Yogyakarta (Indonesia, 2019), has remained in the Champion Division by making the semifinals since then. The losing semifinalists are awarded bronze

medals. This time, India faced host Kazakhstan for a place in the semifinals. The presence of World No. 40 Kirill Gerassimenko gave Kazakhstan an edge, but India's overall strength proved decisive.

Manav Thakkar and Harmeet Desai, ranked 59 and 87 respectively, defeated Gerassimenko in the first and fourth singles, offsetting Sharath's defeat to Aidan Kenzhigulov. In the second match, Harmeet comfortably beat Alan Kurmangaliyev 3-0 to give India a commanding 2-0 lead.

In the crucial fourth singles, Harmeet twice came back from a deficit to overcome Gerassimenko, ending Kazakhstan's medal hopes. Over the past few years, with G. Sathiyar struggling, Harmeet has delivered in key matches. Once again, he did not let his teammates down.

India's 0-3 defeat to a formidable Chinese Taipei in the semifinals – mirroring the result of their 2023 encounter at the same stage – left India celebrating a hat-trick of men's team bronze medals from the Asian Championships.

Overall, despite some disappointments in individual events, there were several joyous moments and positive takeaways for India.